

EUROPEAN ECONOMICS ANALYST

UK Outlook 2026—Catching Down

- We expect another mixed year for the UK economy in 2026, characterised by trend-like growth and further increases in unemployment, but also materially lower inflation and three more Bank Rate cuts to 3%.
- Although real disposable income growth is likely to remain weak in the coming quarters, we see scope for the savings rate to decline further this year as interest rates fall and thus expect some pick-up in consumption growth. Fiscal policy remains contractionary (despite higher near-term spending in the Budget), but the BoE's rate cuts should support growth in 2026. Taken together, we look for 1.4% Q4/Q4 growth this year, up from around 1% in 2025. This matches our estimate of potential and is close to consensus and the MPC's forecast.
- The labour market weakened significantly last year, as below-trend growth and the rise in national insurance contributions weighed on employment. The recent rise in redundancies points to further labour market softening ahead, and we expect the unemployment rate to rise to 5.3% by March. As a result, we expect wage growth to broadly normalise this year. Private sector regular pay growth has already slowed from around 6% to about 4% over the last 12 months, and we forecast further cooling to 3.1% by end-2026.
- Inflation surprised significantly to the upside last year and services inflation remains elevated. That said, measures of underlying services inflation have made notable progress, and we expect material further disinflation from unwinding base effects (in both energy and regulated prices), a cut in household energy bills and weaker private rent inflation. As a result, we project services inflation to slow significantly and headline inflation should decline to 2.1% in Q2.
- We therefore continue to expect three further Bank Rate cuts this year to a 3% terminal rate, which matches our estimate of the neutral rate. Our baseline is that the MPC lowers Bank Rate in March, June, and September, although a more drawn-out cutting cycle is possible if the near-term data are firmer than we anticipate.
- While the UK faces considerable fiscal challenges, our analysis suggests that markets still penalise gilts excessively, and we look for lower gilt yields alongside lower Bank Rate and inflation. The government remains focused on lifting potential growth via planning reform, improving the EU trading relationship and boosting labour market participation. Structural reforms, however, face

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challenges from political uncertainty and rising employment costs.

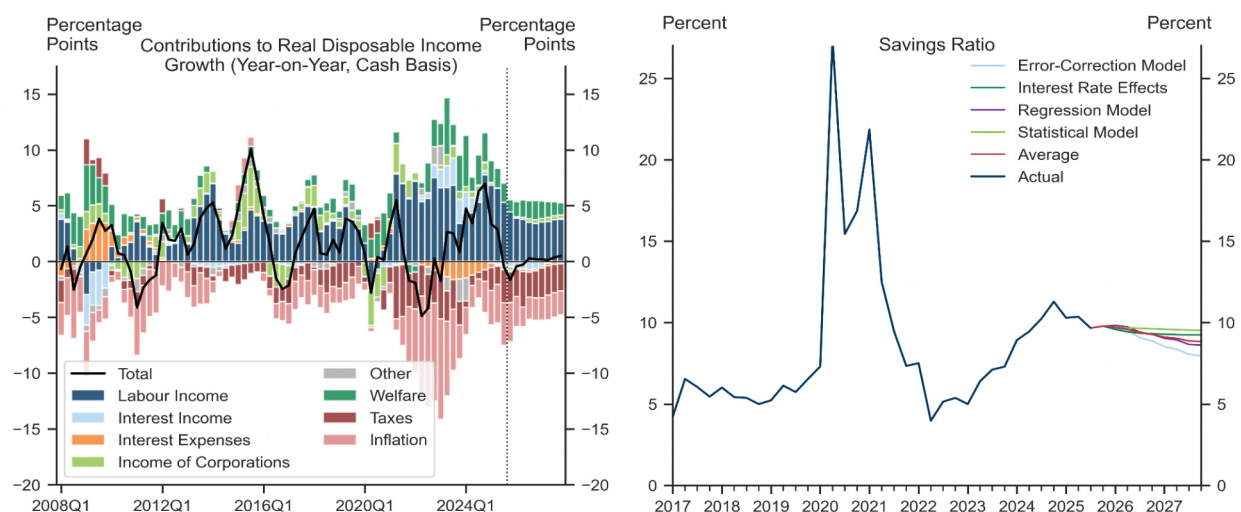
UK Outlook 2026—Catching Down

We expect 2026 to be another mixed year for the UK economy. We look for trend-like growth and a further increase in the unemployment rate, but we also expect a significant cooling in inflation and three more Bank Rate cuts to 3%.

Trend-Like Growth

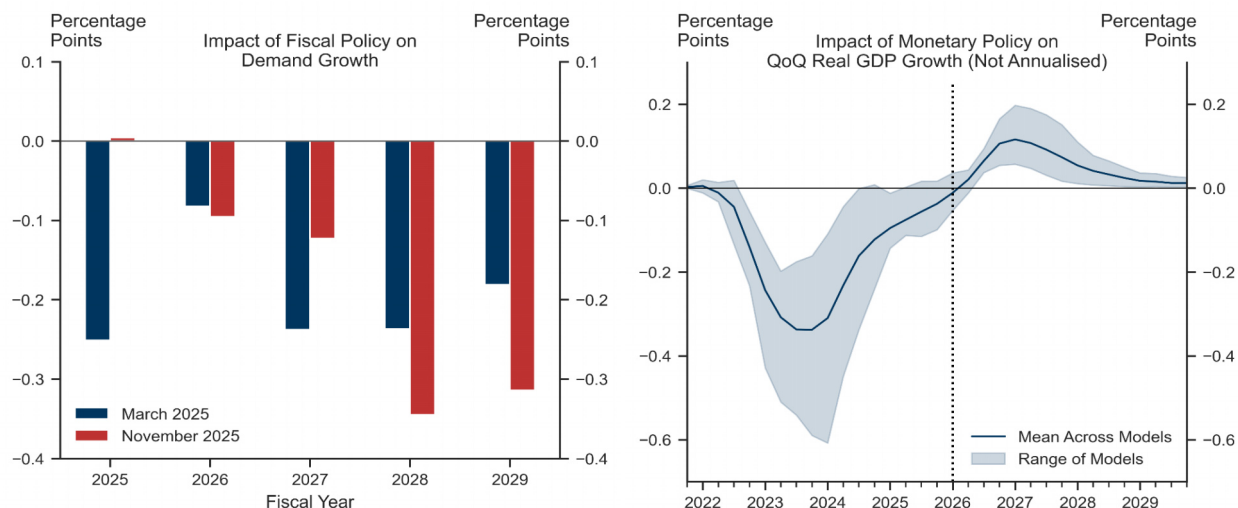
Consumer spending remains weak and the household savings rate is high (Exhibit 1). Real disposable income growth is likely to remain weak in coming quarters given wage growth moderation, elevated mortgage rates and a larger fiscal drag on household incomes. That said, our models indicate that the savings rate will likely decline further this year as interest rates fall and consumption catches up with past increases in real incomes. Taken together, our analysis suggests that consumption is likely to grow at 1.3% on a Q4/Q4 basis in 2026, up from 0.7% last year.

Exhibit 1: Weak Real Income Growth, But a Consumption Boost from Lower Savings



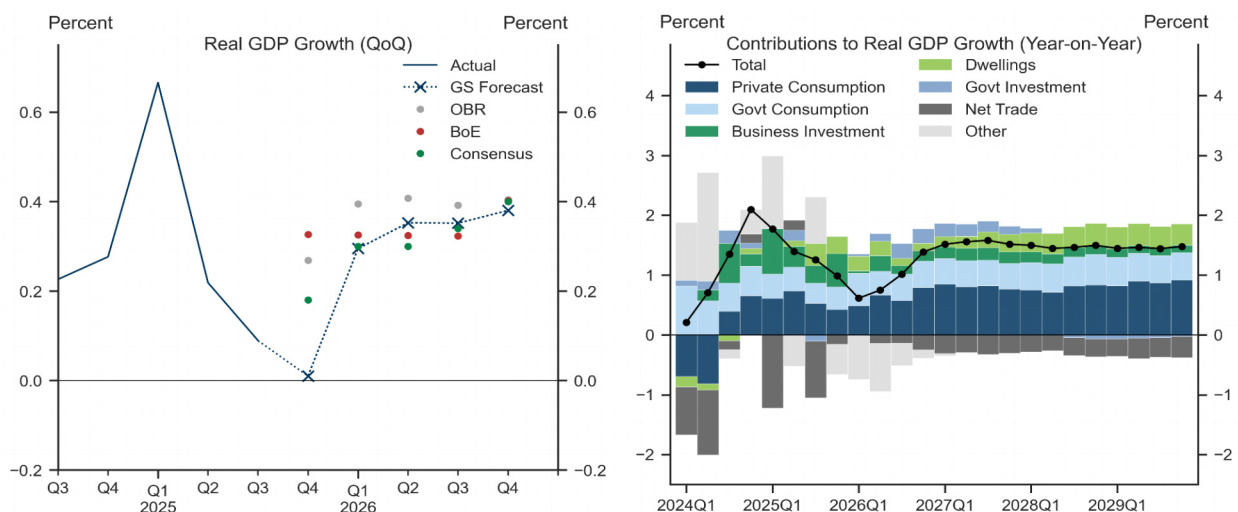
Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

We expect a roughly neutral fiscal/monetary growth impulse this year. The Autumn Budget turned out more expansionary for near-term growth than anticipated, with the OBR estimating that the new policies will raise the level of real GDP by 0.1% in fiscal year (FY) 2026. But the OBR forecasts continue to point to a notable consolidation in the cyclically adjusted primary balance in FY2026 and our fiscal impulse still indicates a slight drag on growth from fiscal policy this year (Exhibit 2, left). Monetary policy, however, is likely to support growth in 2026. While the level of Bank Rate remains restrictive, the monetary policy growth impulse should turn slightly positive, following 150bp of cuts so far (Exhibit 2, right).

Exhibit 2: We Look for a Broadly Neutral Monetary/Fiscal Mix This Year

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, OBR

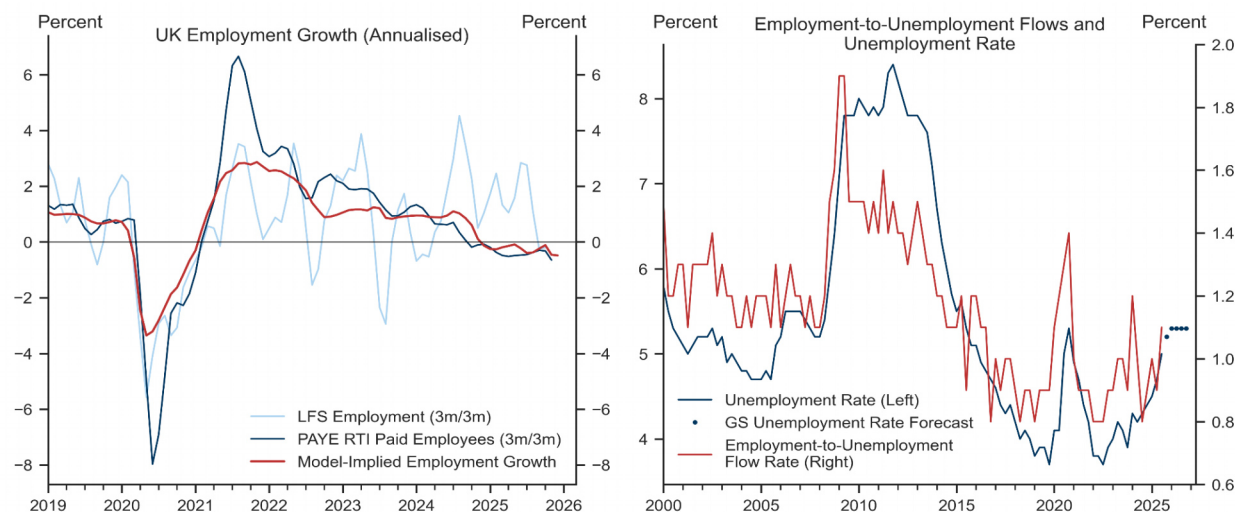
Taken together, we look for a 1.4% Q4/Q4 growth rate for this year, up from around 1% in 2025. This matches our estimate of potential and is close to consensus and the MPC's forecast.

Exhibit 3: We Expect Trend-Like Growth in 2026

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, OBR, Bank of England, Bloomberg

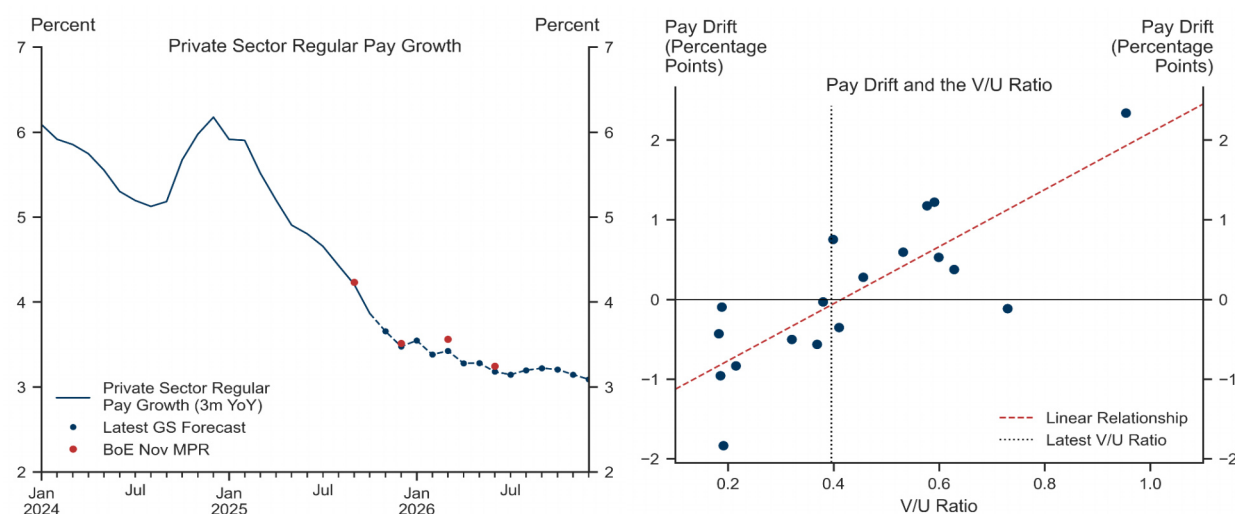
Soft Labour Market, Inflation Normalisation

The labour market weakened significantly last year, as below-trend growth and the rise in national insurance contributions weighed on employment (Exhibit 4). The recent rise in layoffs—including job separations and redundancies—points to further labour market softening ahead. We therefore expect the unemployment rate to rise to 5.3% in March. As growth picks up towards potential, we see the unemployment rate stabilising for the remainder of 2026.

Exhibit 4: Further Labour Market Softening Ahead

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

Given rising slack, lower headline inflation and a smaller national living wage (NLW) increase, we expect wage growth to broadly normalise this year. Private sector regular pay growth slowed from around 6% to 3.8% over the last 12 months (on a three-month year-over-year basis) and we forecast further cooling to 3.1% by end-2026. While the BoE agents' pay settlement expectation for 2026 surprised to the upside at 3.5% in the November MPR, its sample is still small at this point and other pay settlement indicators (such as Brightmine) remain lower. Also, pay drift—the difference between pay settlements and actual pay growth—tends to fall when the labour market loosens (as captured by increases in the vacancy/unemployment ratio).

Exhibit 5: We Look for Pay Growth Normalisation

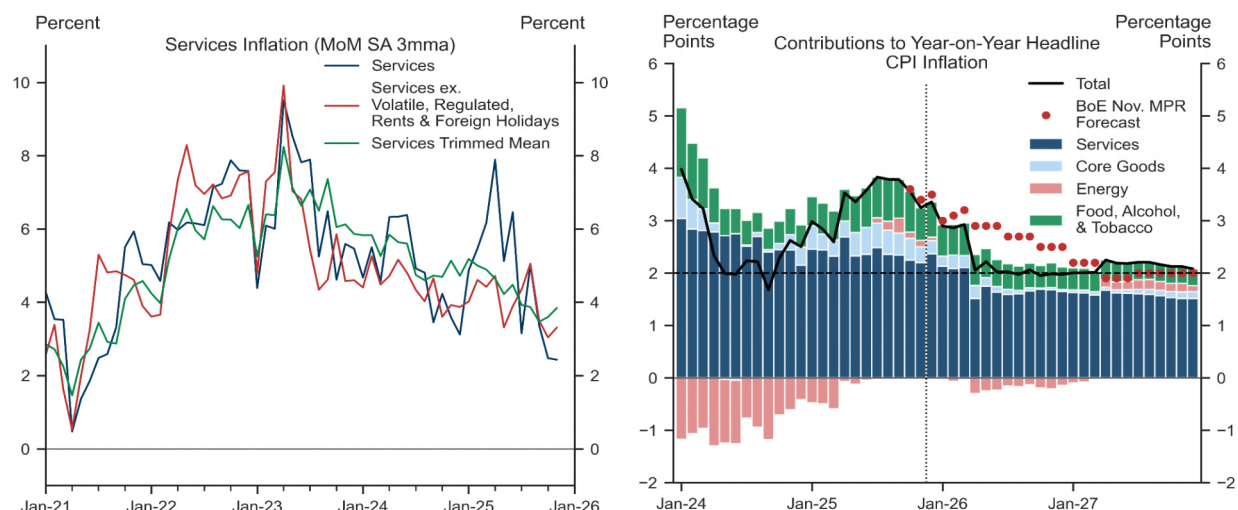
“Pay drift” on the right side refers to the gap between private sector regular pay growth and the BoE’s measure of average private sector pay settlements. Data are shown on an annual basis.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, Bank of England

Inflation surprised significantly to the upside this year and services inflation remained high at 4.4% in November. That said, measures of underlying services inflation have

made progress recently, with the three-month annualised run-rate of the Bank's main exclusion measure now running at 3.3%. Given unwinding base effects (in both energy and regulated prices), a cut in household energy bills and prospects for weaker private rent inflation, we look for further progress in the coming months. As a result, we project services inflation to slow significantly while headline inflation should decelerate to 2.1% in Q2.

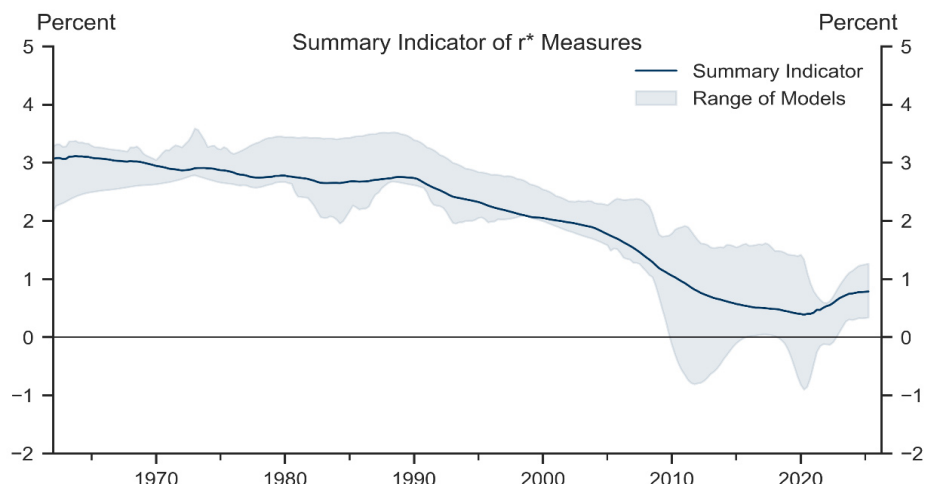
Exhibit 6: Inflation is Likely to Slow Materially in 2026



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, Bank of England

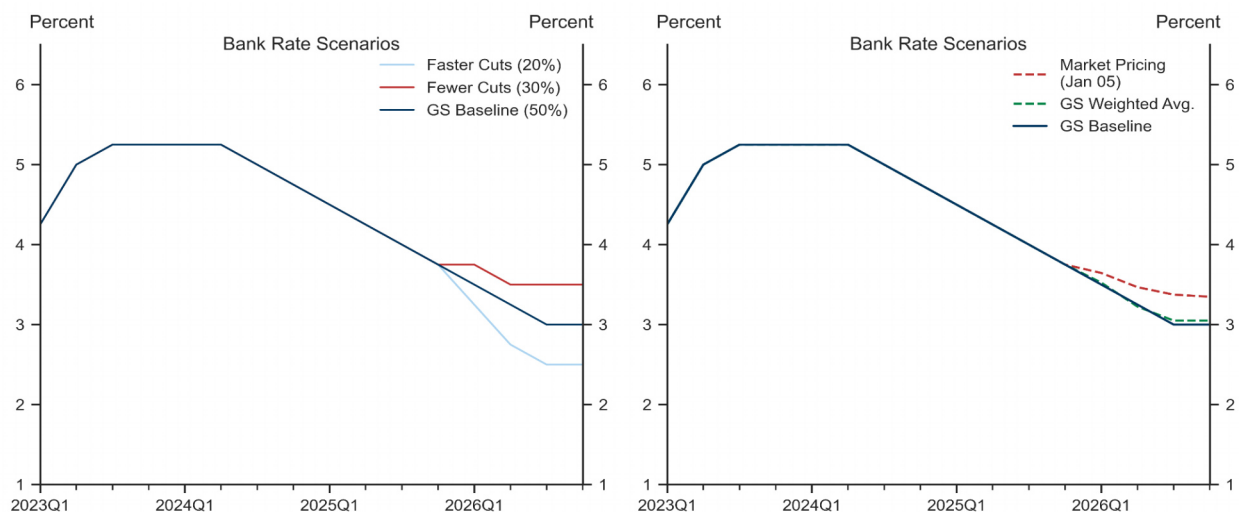
Three More Rate Cuts

Our forecasts imply further slack emerging in the labour market this year, at the same time that inflationary pressures are fading. We think this will allow the MPC to normalise policy towards a more neutral level. Moreover, our estimates suggest that the neutral rate (or r^*) is around 3%, broadly consistent with the mid-point of the MPC's 2-4% range. As a result, our optimal policy simulations—which use a small macro model to trace out the path for Bank Rate which best delivers on the MPC's remit—point to steady cuts ahead. Consistent with this, we expect three further 25bp cuts this year to a 3% terminal rate.

Exhibit 7: We See the Neutral Rate Around 3%

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, IMF, Federal Reserve, Bank of England, Consensus Economics

The timing of future Bank Rate reductions will depend heavily on the incoming data. The latest MPC commentary suggests that the Committee could cut slower than quarterly if the data come in line with the Bank's projections. Our economic forecasts are weaker than the Bank's estimates, however, and so we think that the Committee will cut more steadily than the latest guidance implies. As such, we see cuts in March, June, and September as baseline, although a more drawn-out cutting cycle is possible if the data are firmer than we expect.

Exhibit 8: We Look for Three 25bp Cuts This Year

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, Bloomberg

Fiscal Challenges, Political Risk and Potential Growth in Focus

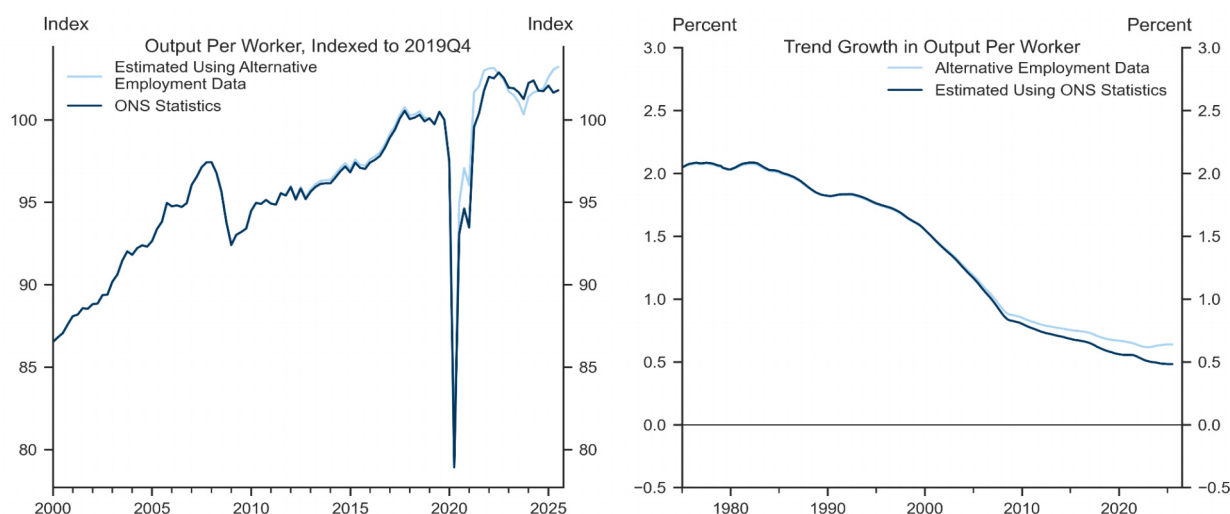
The UK faces considerable fiscal challenges, requiring a decisive consolidation. After slippage against in-year forecasts in the last two years, we expect investors to focus on whether the government delivers the sharp consolidation pencilled in for 2026. We do see scope for modest slippage because the OBR's near-term growth forecasts are somewhat higher than ours, and there is also uncertainty around revenues from some

tax measures that come into effect in 2026. But we still see a meaningful consolidation overall, with some help from lower interest rates.

More broadly, our analysis suggests that the UK's fiscal position looks less vulnerable than some other European countries, notably France. We find that markets penalise gilts excessively compared to its fundamentals, likely related to lingering inflation concerns and the 2022 mini-budget episode. Given our expectations for inflation progress and additional Bank Rate cuts, we see scope for gilts to realign with their macro fundamentals. While the re-emergence of political volatility is a risk, our strategists expect gilt yields to decline to 4% by year-end.

Following the OBR's productivity growth downgrade, the UK's supply-side performance and the government's efforts to boost growth are likely to remain in focus. The latest data do point to a recent pick-up in productivity growth if one uses the payrolls data rather than the less reliable Labour Force Survey figures to measure changes in the number of employees. But the underlying growth trend remains sluggish, even if some of the slowdown in the past 15 years probably reflects the lasting effects of the financial crisis and Brexit on potential supply.

Exhibit 9: Productivity Growth Trend Remains Sluggish



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics, ONS

In the coming year, the government's efforts to boost the supply side of the economy are likely to focus on raising labour force participation (especially among young people), further reforms to the planning system and improving the trading relationship with the EU.

On participation, the rollout of the government's Youth Guarantee Scheme will begin early this year, while the Milburn Review into the causes of low labour market participation among young people will be published in the summer. That said, attempts to boost youth employment may be limited by weakness in labour demand and by rising employment costs resulting from the employer National Insurance hike and sharp increases in minimum wage rates for young people. Survey data from the Decision Maker Panel also point to risks of a drag on employment growth from AI in the coming years.

On planning, the Planning and Infrastructure Bill came into effect in December and the government has also announced a consultation on further changes to the National

Planning Policy Framework (NPPF). We continue to expect planning reforms to meaningfully boost residential investment, although ongoing weakness in housing starts and planning applications suggests that the impact will be backloaded. We do think that this is likely to have some impact on productivity through increased labour mobility, although the impact will likely be very gradual.

In terms of the EU relationship, the government's focus will be on completing the veterinary agreement, emissions trading scheme linkage, and youth mobility deal that the two sides agreed to last May. But investors are likely to ask whether more can be done to improve the trading relationship. Officials have suggested that one potential area to revisit would be mutual recognition of professional qualifications, which could help boost services trade. Recent months have also seen renewed political debate about the possible benefits of re-entering a customs union. However, the Prime Minister has said that such a move would unravel trade deals with other countries including the US. He has instead indicated that the government could pursue further sector-specific deals in which greater alignment with EU rules is offered in return for improved market access.

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